

IDEA 120. Digital Practices in the Arts. 4 hours.

CRN: 41677

Spring 2026

Instructor: Tiffany Funk

Time: Tuesdays and Thursdays, 9:30-10:45a Art & Exhibition Hall, rm 3227

Contact/Office: tfunk4@uic.edu / 5th floor A&E Hall

Office Hours: Thursdays, 12-2:00p (in person, 5th floor A&E Hall, or schedule for Zoom)



Trump loves Cats, images produced using Midjourney, a text-to-image AI generator, with the prompt “Photorealistic Donald Trump in Oval Office loves handsome orange tabby cat”

COURSE DESCRIPTION:

Digital media—like Instagram photos, TikTok stories, Google searches, Reddit threads, and WhatsApp messages—forms most of the content we create and consume daily. Existing digital media and the digitized versions of the old media before it is available to more people than ever before, while even more digital content is created each day than in the whole of human history up to the creation of the internet. Protests, social justice movements, and political campaigns are won or lost through online organization and the dissemination of viral digital media. The influence of digital media on our lives continues to grow. In the vast, interconnected global village of the internet, who are we in relationship to, and how do we thoughtfully read digital media? And, even more, what skills are most beneficial to strengthen our careers and communities and lead our own creative endeavors and social movements in this media landscape? These are some primary questions we will explore in this digital practices course.

IDEA 120 meets twice weekly on Tuesdays and Thursdays from 9:30 am to 10:45 am. Any changes to this structure will be discussed in advance during class.

Our course explores digital media as an art form, bringing it together with design, cultural, and technology studies into an interactive, collaborative class.

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Our course is oriented toward making, writing, building, and identifying relevant skills for a digital media toolkit and historical and theoretical introductions to practices applicable to creative and critical thinkers working across disciplines.

This course is required for BA in IDEAS. Extensive computer use (and internet access) is required. If you do not have access to a laptop, you may request to borrow one from the university (<https://it.uic.edu/services-support/student-resources/online-learning/>).

Course Outcomes:

- Students will demonstrate a basic understanding of how key ideas of digital media practices in design and the arts are materialized through current digital media creation tools and their underlying social and technological systems.
- Students will demonstrate an understanding of digital media resources in design and the arts.
- Students will demonstrate an ability to use current creative digital media tools (purpose-built or appropriated) and systems in design and the arts.
- Students will demonstrate a basic understanding of how digital media practices in design and the arts (including architectural, visual, environmental, theatrical, musical, and art historical) reflect and shape technological and cultural conditions, including questions of community, personal narrative, privacy, and security.

Assessment Methods:

- Short projects and class readings will evaluate students' understanding of how key ideas of digital media practices in design and art disciplines are materialized through current digital tools and systems.
- Short projects will evaluate students' understanding of digital media resources in design and arts disciplines.
- Short projects will evaluate the student's ability to use current digital media tools and systems in design and arts disciplines.
- A website project will evaluate students' ability to apply computer programming concepts.
- Assigned readings, videos to watch, and audio to listen to will challenge students to think critically about how digital media practices in design and the arts shape technological and cultural conditions concerning questions of community, personal narrative, privacy, and security.

Course Content and Materials:

Pre-recorded lectures, texts, articles, videos, audio clips, and additional resources like example files and tutorials can be accessed on the course GitHub repository under the folder for the current week. You will be responsible for watching, reading, and listening to each week's materials, as their content will be explored further in your weekly assignments and projects.

Course link: https://github.com/fetalcircuit/IDEA_120_S26/blob/Spring2026/SCHEDULE.md

***Please bookmark this page. Links will be available via Blackboard, but all course content will be shared through Github.

Git, and Github

We will extensively use Git and GitHub to post writing responses and project files, and it will serve as the central hub for course materials.

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Git (<https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Git>) is a file management system primarily used by programmers in software development (and also used by artists, writers, designers, scientists, among many others) that allows them to manage their projects as "repositories" or all-inclusive packages that can be managed and new versions updated ("pushed" to a server) easily.

GitHub

(<https://www.howtogeek.com/180167/htg-explains-what-is-github-and-what-do-geeks-use-it-for/>) is a web service that hosts these repositories. GitHub uses Git, but Git does not necessarily use GitHub.

A free GitHub account is required for this class. Create an account here: (<https://github.com/join>) and email me at tfunk4@uic.edu with your GitHub username.

Coursework: (100 points total)

Github Poetry Project	20
Green Screen Project	20
Non-Linear Narrative Project	20
Final Portfolio Project	20
Attendance and Discussion Participation	20
Total	100

****All assignments will be explained in class and on Github.**

Revision Policy:

After you turn in projects and receive feedback, you will have the chance to revise your assignments using what you've learned. Contact me at tfunk4@uic.edu or after class to arrange how to turn in revisions.

Grading Key:

A	outstanding accomplishment in all assignments (technically and conceptually) excellent engagement with ideas and materials excellent participation in classroom community (vocal, inquisitive, and thoughtful) full attendance, or responsibly acquires class content covered during infrequent absences exceptional progress in the artistic/project process
B	above average accomplishment in all assignments with work submitted on time strong engagement with ideas and materials average conceptual or formal impetus full attendance, or responsibly acquires class content covered during infrequent absences acceptable progress in the artistic/project process
C	average accomplishment of all assignments with work submitted on time some engagement with ideas and materials

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	some participation in the classroom community ignores class content covered during absences unless prompted student shows a lack of motivation and interest in thoroughly developing projects
D	the work does not meet the assignment criteria some assignments are not completed or completed in a perfunctory manner little engagement with ideas and materials irregular or damaging participation in the classroom community irregular attendance and minimal progress
F	many assignments not completed or completed in a perfunctory manner little or no evidence of engagement with ideas and materials lack of participation in the classroom community failure to arrive prepared for class routinely irregular attendance and little or no evidence of progress

*NOTE - Merely turning in all assignments is not a guarantee of a C or above.

Contact / Credit Hour Policies:

This class is a 4-hour credit course. You should expect to read, watch, or listen to around 4 hours of required course materials per week, in addition to the time it will take to complete assignments. Because of the pace of the course, completing assignments on time is crucial for success.

ATTENDANCE POLICY

Attendance is required. Students are expected to attend all classes and be present for the entire duration. Announcements and directions will be given at the beginning of class, and you must arrive on time. Absences, late arrivals, and leaving class early will negatively affect your grade.

- Students are granted three unexcused absences/wellness days.
- An excused absence includes:
- Documentation of illness or medical intervention (COVID test, doctor/nurse/therapist note, equivalent proof of medical procedure)
- Documentation (image/photos, misc.) of unforeseen circumstances (traffic accident, significant public transportation delays, family illness/death, etc.
- After three unexcused absences, all subsequent absences must be excused, or they will lower your letter grade by one.
- One letter grade will be dropped for each additional unexcused absence.
- Missing class on your scheduled presentation/critique days is equivalent to missing (i.e., failing an exam). See the coursework/point totals above.

***IMPORTANT: When absent, COMMUNICATE WITH ME VIA EMAIL ASAP. While unforeseen circumstances occur, IT IS YOUR RESPONSIBILITY TO MAKE UP PAST WORK AND COURSE CONTENT. AN EXCUSED ABSENCE DOES NOT EXCUSE YOU FROM COURSE CONTENT TAUGHT OR PROJECT DEADLINES.

Religious Holidays

Following Illinois state laws and with respect for cultural diversity, we will make every effort to avoid scheduling examinations or requiring student projects to be turned in or completed on religious holidays. Students who wish to observe their religious holidays must notify the instructor by the tenth day of the term that they will be absent

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unless their religious holiday is observed on or before the tenth day; in such cases, students must notify the instructor at least five days in advance of the date when they will be absent.

OUR INCLUSIVE LEARNING ENVIRONMENT

UIC values diversity and inclusion. Regardless of age, disability, ethnicity, race, gender, gender identity, sexual orientation, socioeconomic status, geographic background, religion, political ideology, language, or culture, we expect all members of this class to contribute to a respectful, welcoming, and inclusive environment for every other member of our class. If there are aspects of the instruction or design of this course that result in barriers to your inclusion, engagement, accurate assessment, or achievement, please notify me as soon as possible.

Disability Accommodation Procedures

UIC is committed to the full inclusion and participation of people with disabilities in all aspects of university life. If you face or anticipate disability-related barriers while at UIC, please connect with the Disability Resource Center (DRC) at drc.uic.edu, via email at drc@uic.edu, or call (312) 413-2183 to create a plan for reasonable accommodations. To receive accommodations, you must disclose the disability to the DRC, complete an interactive registration process with the DRC, and provide me with a Letter of Accommodation (LOA). Upon receipt of a LOA, I will gladly work with you and the DRC to implement approved accommodations.

Classroom Conduct Policy

Community Agreement: Ground Rules for a Safe/Brave Space:

- Be present (turn off/mute cell phones and remove yourself from other distractions)
- Be respectful
- Assume goodwill
- Challenge with care: approach discussion as a “think out loud”
- Take space/make space
- Identities stay, learning leaves
- Try not to make assumptions, seek to understand, not to judge
- Be open to challenges as an opportunity to learn something new
- Be open to different perspectives
- Debate the concepts, not the person
- Be flexible when things don’t work
- Share helpful tips
- Use preferred names and gender pronouns
- Be willing to work together
- Be mindful of one another’s privacy

UIC STUDENT RESOURCES

- Campus-wide Resources for UIC Students
- Current Student Resources (a one-stop shop for links to resources in the following categories: General, Academic, Student Support, Student Life, Technology, Health and Safety, and Getting Around Campus): <https://today.uic.edu/resources/current-student-resources/>
- UIC Tutoring Resources: <https://tutoring.uic.edu/>

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- ***Offices, Programs, and Initiatives Supporting the UIC Undergraduate Experience and Academic Programs with particular attention to the Student Success Units:
- <https://vpuaap.uic.edu/offices-and-programs/success-units/>
- Students dealing with personal hardships who need resources and assistance should consult the U&I Care Program, supported by UIC's Office of the Dean of Students: <https://dos.uic.edu/student-assistance/uicare>
- Student Guide for Information Technology (a comprehensive resource for UIC students describing the most commonly used IT services and tools supporting their success): <https://uofi.app.box.com/s/0nyho51r24yo0pivafibb1nvqogjm401>

***These offices and programs are often the best places to receive immediate assistance and support.

UIC Counseling/Crisis Center

If you are in immediate distress, please call the UIC Counseling Center at (312) 996-3490 to speak directly with a counselor or schedule an appointment. If calling after business hours (which at UIC are typically from 9 am - 5 pm, M- F), press 2 to be connected to a crisis counselor. Additional mental health resources are available on the Counseling Center Resources page.

Academic Integrity: Student Community Standards

UIC is an academic community committed to providing an environment where research, learning, and scholarship can flourish, and all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity. In this community, all members, including faculty, administrators, staff, and students alike, are responsible for upholding the highest standards of academic honesty and quality of academic work so that such an environment exists.

As a student and member of the UIC community, you are expected to adhere to the Community Standards of integrity, accountability, and respect in all of your academic endeavors. When accusations of academic dishonesty occur, the Office of the Dean of Students investigates and adjudicates suspected violations of this student code. Unacceptable behavior includes cheating, unauthorized collaboration, fabrication or falsification, plagiarism, multiple submissions without instructor permission, using unauthorized study aids, coercion regarding grading or evaluation of coursework, and facilitating academic misconduct. Please review the UIC Student Disciplinary Policy for additional information about how instances of academic misconduct are handled towards the goal of developing responsible student behavior.

By submitting your assignments for grading, you acknowledge these terms, declare that your work is solely your own, and promise that, unless authorized by the instructor or proctor, you have not communicated with anyone in any way during an exam or other online assessment. Let's embrace what it means to be a UIC community member and be committed to the values of integrity together.